together and shared my aim and priorities with them. We adopted 'Fight to Win' as our motto. Since training for our operational missions was our most important challenge, I wanted to ensure that my brigades and units were well-led and trained, and in a good state of operational preparedness. Since most combat units in my division had come to peace stations after a three-year stay in operational or high-altitude areas, they also needed to have time for rest and recuperation. I had given orders that as far as possible, units should not be away from their peace locations for more than two months each year.

The moment my posting orders were issued in mid-1996, I started preparing for this assignment. An important war game had been planned by the Western Command HQ for 11 Corps, and Pine Division was a part of it. Therefore, I requested my boss at the Army HQ, Major General M.P.S. Kandal, for permission to go on area familiarization visits to 11 Corps zone. It was critical for me to do so, as my knowledge of the western theatre was inadequate. I could not take any chances with an army commander like Lieutenant General A.K. Gautam, who was reputed to tear into anyone who did not measure up professionally. After the formal welcomes, some of them lukewarm, as most people in Meerut believed that 9 Infantry Division was on its way out, I proceeded on the reconnaissance of my area of operational responsibility (AOR). There was a month to go for the war game. I got hold of my brigade commanders and we discussed various contingency plans. I may not have known each and every place by name, but I became very clear on the rationale, fundamentals and concepts of our war plans. Though we had a defensive role, yet offensive-defence was our byword. Once the war commenced, we could reach out and strike the aggressor even before he crossed the border. The sanctity of the border becomes meaningless when hostilities commence. That's exactly how we played the game.

We had set up our operations rooms within the precincts of the Corps HQ in Jalandhar. The tubular frame of the canvas structures